

The Impacts of COVID-19 on Fast Fashion

By Tayler Payson

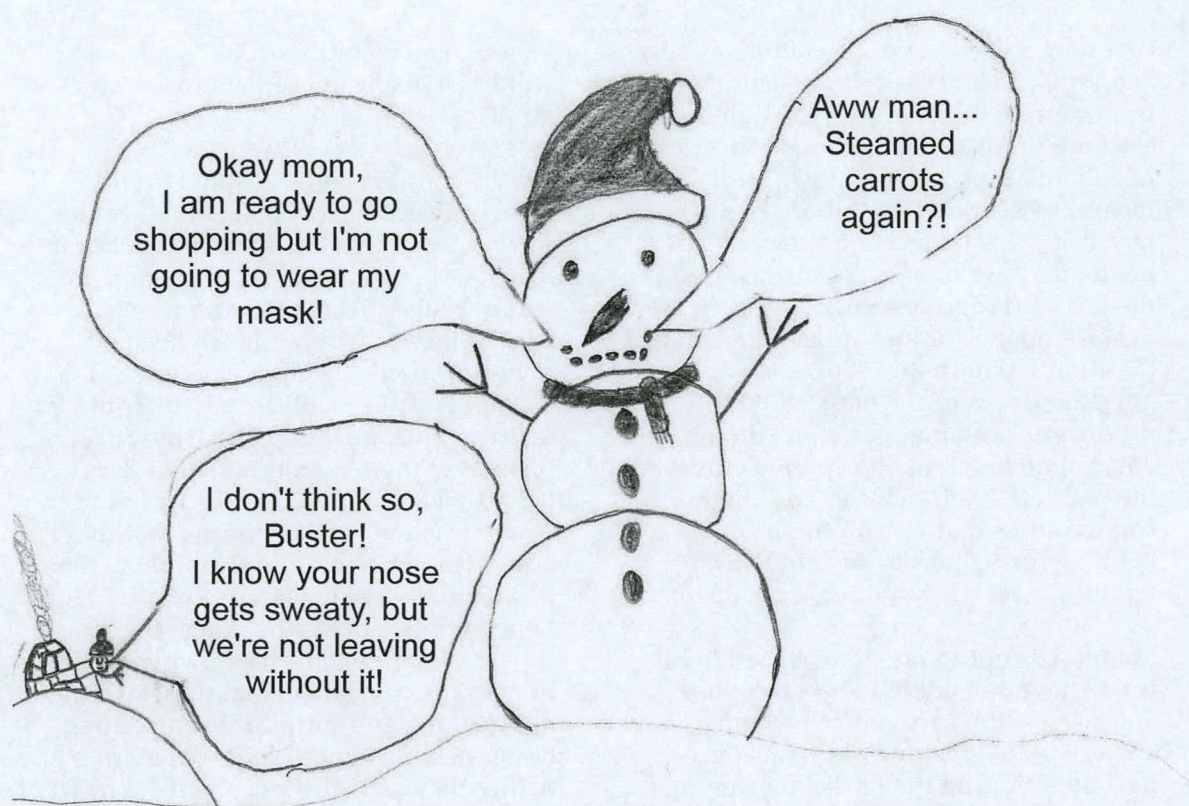
The phrase “fast fashion” has been circulating the internet and other media platforms lately, and with various definitions going around with the term, it is important to define “fast fashion” moving forward in this column (Stanton, 2020). In general terms, fast fashion can be defined as an approach to design, and marketing of inexpensive clothing that can be made in mass production to circulate the fashion industry quickly (Stanton, 2020). Since big brand clothing retailers are following the fast fashion industry, it is creating a significant negative toll on the environment. Most of these effects can be seen in our landfills and our water systems.

Currently, the modern consumer is consuming more textiles than ever before (McFall-Johnsen, 2019). When comparing data taken from the year 2000, fashion companies went from offering two collections per year to five collections per year in 2011 (McFall-Johnsen, 2019). This trend of increasing production also correlates to the increasing consumption of textiles which increased 60% from 2000 to 2014, with consumers keeping their items for half the time they would have in 2000 (McFall-Johnsen, 2019). This means consumers are also contributing more to textile waste. While people may be donating their disposable fashion in order to purchase more, thinking they are giving to the needy, they are not (CBC Marketplace, 2018). This notion of the “clothing deficit” comes from people thinking that if they donate their older, dated clothes they can keep buying new (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Currently 85% of our fast fashion products will end up in a landfill, even when they are donated to the “needy” at the local thrift shop (CBC Marketplace, 2018). When the items do not get sold at the thrift shop, they are sold to other companies to be reused in a different way or sold to third world countries to be sold at their local markets (CBC Marketplace, 2018). However, these items

which are sold at third world markets are usually thrown in the landfill because of the cheap quality, and unwearable conditions (CBC Marketplace, 2018).

Another option for fashion disposal that fashion brands, like H&M, are now offering is a clothing recycling program, where people can bring in their old clothes in exchange for a coupon on their next purchase (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Through these programs, the brand says they will recycle your clothes and turn them into new ones to be sold (CBC Marketplace, 2018). This may be true for some products, less than 1%, but the majority of these “recycled” clothes will end up being sold somewhere else (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Currently, many textiles are made out of many synthetic materials or blends of fibres, those of which impact the potentiality of creating new garments, and contribute to water pollution and carbon emissions (CBC Marketplace, 2018). When producing fashion, many gallons of water are needed to make certain items because of their fibre composition (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Clothing which has a high volume of cotton will require more water use since the fibre is classified as being highly water-intensive (McFall-Johnsen, 2019). Cotton farming near the Aral Sea used up all of the water source in approximately 50 years because cotton needs an absurd amount of water to be processed (McFall-Johnsen, 2019). The Levi’s jeans that you love, needed 2000 gallons of water to make one pair of jeans, which is equivalent to someone being able to drink at least eight cups of water per day for 10 years! (McFall-Johnsen, 2019).

When diving deeper into other fibres used to make clothing, it is shown that the quality of the most widely used fibres are less than optimal and are usually combined to make wearable blends (CBC Marketplace, 2018). So, in order to break down donated clothing to be recycled,



by Dom, age 10

brands would need a lot more material to produce a similar quality item than what it started with because of the original poor quality (CBC Marketplace, 2018).

The fibres in most of our current textiles are made from synthetic fibres, like polyester, which contain microplastics (CBC Marketplace, 2018). When washing clothes, these articles leak microplastics into the ocean and contribute to 31% of the ocean's plastic pollution (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Therefore, a combined effort between the producer and the consumer of fast fashion are to blame for the environmental impacts it has caused over the past decade. Luckily, we as consumers are in control of our buying habits, and the current economic struggles because of COVID-19 should spark an interest in ways to save money and our environment.

COVID-19 and Fast Fashion

As the world becomes united by the devastating health, economic and other burdens caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, we have witnessed many industries closing their physical doors to open online or closing indefinitely (Fashion Revolution, 2020). COVID-19 has had a negative effect on the fashion industry, but positive effects on the environment. Some of the more popular fashion brands have online platforms where consumers can still shop until they drop despite the current economic hardships many people, including front-end retail workers and the production workers are currently facing (Fashion Revolution, 2020; Huet, 2020).

Since the pandemic started, many of the world's leading fashion brands have either donated to pandemic relief or started to cancel preplaced orders from producers (Fashion Revolution &

Chatterjee, Chatterjee, Esther, & Kaninica Sengupta, 2020). The brands that have been cancelling orders are causing many clothing producers in various countries, like Bangladesh, to shut down over 1,000 factories (Fashion Revolution, 2020). Since many of these items were previously made, they are now being thrown into the local garbage system, destroying the overabundance of unwanted merchandise (Fashion Revolution, 2020).

The shut down of the mass clothing producers has a positive effect on the environment yet many negative effects for the workers, their families and their communities that rely on these manufacturing jobs to sustain their families' needs (Chatterjee et al., 2020).

Manufacturers aware of increased textile waste have considered ways to re-use and recycle the garments which are already made: turning old items into new by stripping the fabric to bring it back to its original fibres (Huet, 2020). The problem is that less than 1% of these items will provide quality fibres to re-use in the future (CBC Marketplace, 2018). A suggestion to the fashion industry would be to sell the pre-made items to consumers and start to press their "reset button" on the way they are manufacturing items (Newmark, 2020). This act of "resetting" fashion brands' business mindsets can allow the opportunity to shift from the traditional wholesale model towards focusing on the more sustainable notion of quality over quantity (Newmark, 2020).

Another potential outcome the fashion industry may see due to COVID-19 could be an abundance of clothing surplus stores due to a steady overproduction of clothing before the pandemic (Newmark, 2020 & Fashion Revolution, 2020). These stores would be similar to the military surplus stores which arose following the cessation of World War II, when the military had an overabundance of military equipment which was no longer needed (Newmark, 2020).

Allowing for the sales of previously made items would prevent the pollution which

arises when countries, like Bangladesh, would be disposing of the unwanted goods.

On the contrary, some fashion brands have been seeing a decline in their sales since the pandemic has started, but brands like H&M, Topshop and Lululemon are barely being affected (Chatterjee et al., 2020). Since these brands are deemed to be affordable fashion, who have also conveniently "greenwashed" their brand, many people are still purchasing from them over their competitors like Zara (Chatterjee et al., 2020). When a brand "greenwashes" itself it means that they advertise as being more sustainable than they actually are (Chatterjee et al., 2020). For example, H&M's clothing recycling program mentioned earlier, wherein the brand tells consumers that they take their old clothing and turn it into something brand new for their brand. When in reality they can only use about 1% of what is donated and they sell the rest (CBC Marketplace, 2018). Most consumers do not know this, therefore by shopping with H&M and donating to their old clothing they feel as though they are not contributing to climate change, when they actually are (Chatterjee et al., 2020).

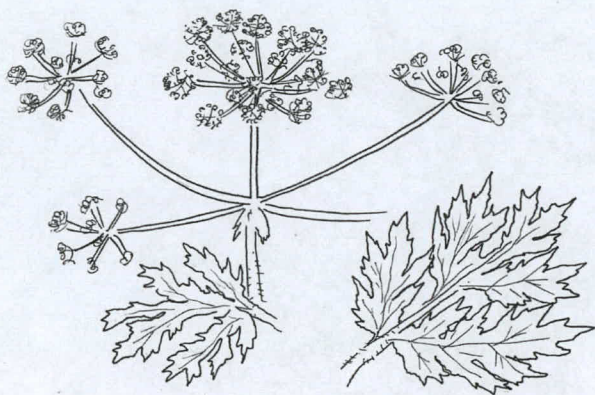
Conclusion

The fashion industry as we know it will be drastically different in a post-COVID-19 world in all fashion sectors: designer, supplier, retailer and consumer (Huet, 2020). Although as consumers we can not change the other levels on the chain, we are responsible for our own actions when it comes to fast fashion and the environment. Being a smart, educated consumer will allow ourselves to make environmentally friendly decisions when the world goes back to a new "normal".

Use this paper as a gateway to open your mind to the impact's consumers make on a daily basis which in turn negatively impacts the environment, and remember this:

"Well, the planet is enjoying the perks of manufacturing coming to a halt and less cars on the road, in the form of reduced global warming, but we need to revive economic activity as soon as possible or a bleak future awaits us!" (Chatterjee et al., 2020)

It is possible to contribute to a thriving economy without constantly purchasing fast fashion. Let's think of our environment, and the future population who will endure it if we do not make a change.



References

- Chatterjee, S., Chatterjee, S., Esther, & Kaninica Sengupta. (2020, May 8). Fast fashion and the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic. Retrieved from <https://www.voicesofyouth.org/blog/fast-fashion-and-impact-covid-19-pandemic>
- CBC Marketplace (2018, January 19). Retrieved from <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eIU32XNj8PM>
- Fashion Revolution. (2020, March). *The impact of COVID-19 on the people who make our clothes*. Fashion Revolution. <https://www.fashionrevolution.org/the-impact-of-covid-19-on-the-people-who-make-our-clothes/>
- Huet, N. (2020, April 22). Could the coronavirus crisis spell the end of fast fashion? Retrieved from <https://www.euronews.com/2020/04/22/could-the-coronavirus-crisis-spell-the-end-of-fast-fashion>
- McFall-Johnsen, M. (2019, October 21). The fashion industry emits more carbon than international flights and maritime shipping combined. Here are the biggest ways it impacts the planet. Retrieved from <https://www.businessinsider.com/fast-fashion-environmental-impact-pollution-emissions-waste-water-2019-10>
- Newmark, L. (2020, May 14). Fast fashion faces shake-up in post-Covid-19 world. Retrieved from https://www.just-style.com/analysis/fast-fashion-faces-shake-up-in-post-covid-19-world_id138679.aspx
- Stanton, A. (2020, April 24). What is fast fashion, anyway? Retrieved from <https://www.thegoodtrade.com/features/what-is-fast-fashion>

Tayler Payson is a recent B.Ed graduate from Queen's University where she studied Primary/Junior education and specialized in exceptional learners. After completing a class on environmental education, Tayler became increasingly interested in reducing her fast fashion consumption. She did some research and has made it a goal of hers to only purchase "new" items that come from consignment stores, from friends, or from "mainstream" stores using gift cards. She wanted to know how COVID-19 has impacted the fast fashion industry, in hopes that it would have people reducing their unnecessary spending.

Copyright of Pathways: the Ontario journal of outdoor education is the property of Council of Outdoor Educators of Ontario and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.